Museum Pieces

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Persecuted people have neither the leisure nor the means to work on museum pieces. During the first three centuries the true Christians were an unpopular minority, both with the Roman Empire and the Jewish Establishment. Often the persecution was overt. Once Christianity became a state religion, rulers would have the means to cover the cost.

Consider the 'purple MSS', of which there are four of any size: GA 022, 023, 042 and 043. The parchment (leather) was stained purple and the text was written with silver ink. Now then, such documents were not prepared for ordinary use, because ordinary use would wear them out. For ordinary use you use ordinary materials. So why would someone contract the production of a 'purple MS'? Might a ruler think that thereby he could curry favor with God? Or might it be a symbol of the state religion? And who would be called upon to do the work? It would certainly be an artisan, not a textual scholar. An artisan would know nothing about textual quality; he would simply use whatever exemplar was handy, or was handed to him. If he made mistakes, no one would ever notice them. I consider the purple MSS to be museum pieces. They were not part of the normal transmission.

Now consider the MSS with fancy and expensive artwork. Again, such documents were not being prepared for ordinary use. In 2014 I spent nine days on the Mt. Athos peninsula, with its twenty independent monasteries. I visited five of them. I talked with the librarian of three of them. I was taken to the treasury of two of them. The only MSS that are in the treasuries are those with fancy and expensive artwork; the quality of text is simply not a factor. When talking with the librarians I raised the matter of lines of textual transmission in the MSS and was met with a blank look; they had no idea what I was talking about (their life is governed by tradition). But why was that artwork created? Why were elaborate cathedrals constructed? I suppose it was their way of honoring God. Monks in monasteries all have a work assignment: some work in the kitchen, some work in the garden, some copy manuscripts and some do artwork; it is their religious duty. The artist doing the artwork would know nothing about the quality of the text that his work was decorating. Some of the ink colors may have been almost as precious as gold or silver, not easy to come by. Decorated MSS were not for ordinary use and thus had a chance to survive. They were museum pieces.

Now consider the number of columns of text per page. About 10% of the papyri have two columns, the rest have one column. As for the uncials: one has four columns, GA 01 (aleph); three have three columns, GA 03 (B), 048 and 053; around 55% have two columns, and the rest have one. As for the minuscules: GA 460 has three columns; less than 15% have two columns, and the rest have one. For ease of reading, one column is best and two is alright; three and four are inferior. Codex

Aleph (Sinaiticus) is a curiosity: its text is clearly fabricated, not belonging to any known line of transmission. With four columns it evidently was not intended for public reading or ordinary use. Codex B (Vaticanus) is also a curiosity: its text is also clearly fabricated, not belonging to any known line of transmission. Besides having three columns, it is written on very fine vellum, and therefore was not intended for public reading or ordinary use. I would say that those two MSS, along with A, D, W and others, survived because they were not used, and they were not used because the quality of their text was too poor to be used. They are museum pieces.

I believe that from the very beginning the Christians used books, not scrolls, to make copies of the NT writings. A book is more efficient and practical. With a book you can easily find the place you are looking for; with a scroll it is far more difficult. A book is written on both sides of the sheet, while a scroll is written on only one side, so a scroll wastes half of the available space. With the need to proliferate copies, the Christians could not afford to waste that space. And what material could they use? Before the invention of paper, there was just papyrus and parchment. Papyrus would be far more plentiful and less expensive than parchment (leather). Further, papyrus is simply not an adequate material for making scrolls; it is more suited for making books.

However, there is definitely a down-side to using papyrus. It is fragile. It is made with strips of pith from the stem of the papyrus plant. If it gets wet, it falls apart. Although it is vegetable, it is impervious; ink does not sink in, but dries as a crust on the surface. If you flex the sheet, the ink may fly off, leaving no trace on the papyrus. A book on papyrus sent from congregation to congregation would probably be falling apart before it got to the twentieth one. To survive for seventeen or eighteen centuries a manuscript on papyrus would have to be buried in desert sand without having been used. Our oldest papyrus manuscript of any size, P^{66}, has an average of two mistakes per verse, stupid mistakes, nonsensical mistakes. It would be psychologically impossible to use it for devotional reading or study, so it was buried in desert sand. $P^{45,46,47,75}$ are all bad, and they survived because they were buried in desert sand, without having been used. (Personally, the only value that I ascribe to those early papyri is that they prove that any reading that they contain is early—veritable museum pieces.)

So, what is my point; why did I write this article? My point is that ‘museum pieces’ were not prepared in order to preserve a pure text; they were prepared for other reasons. It follows that we should not expect to find a good text in museum pieces, and therefore they should not be depended upon as we work to identify the original wording of the Text. Any and all MSS need to be placed in a line of transmission; a copy that is not part of a line of transmission is a fabricated copy, not an honest one.

From the very beginning, the vast majority of copies of the NT writings were made by honest people, people sincerely trying to make faithful copies. Those copies were made to be used, and therefore were worn out and could not survive, the more so if

made on papyrus. That is why there are no 'Byzantine' MSS from the earliest centuries. The earliest MSS that are even partially Byzantine are usually dated to the fifth century. **However**, before 1881, the academic world, including Westcott himself (!), held that the Syriac Peshitta was produced in the second century, and it's text is heavily 'Byzantine'. The Latin tradition is more Byzantine than anything else. Even the Coptic tradition is half Byzantine. Whoever produced P^{66} had a second century Byzantine exemplar, because he alternated freely between 'Byzantine' and 'Alexandrian' readings. It follows that the Byzantine text certainly existed in the second century. I hold that Family 35 was the core of the Byzantine tradition.